

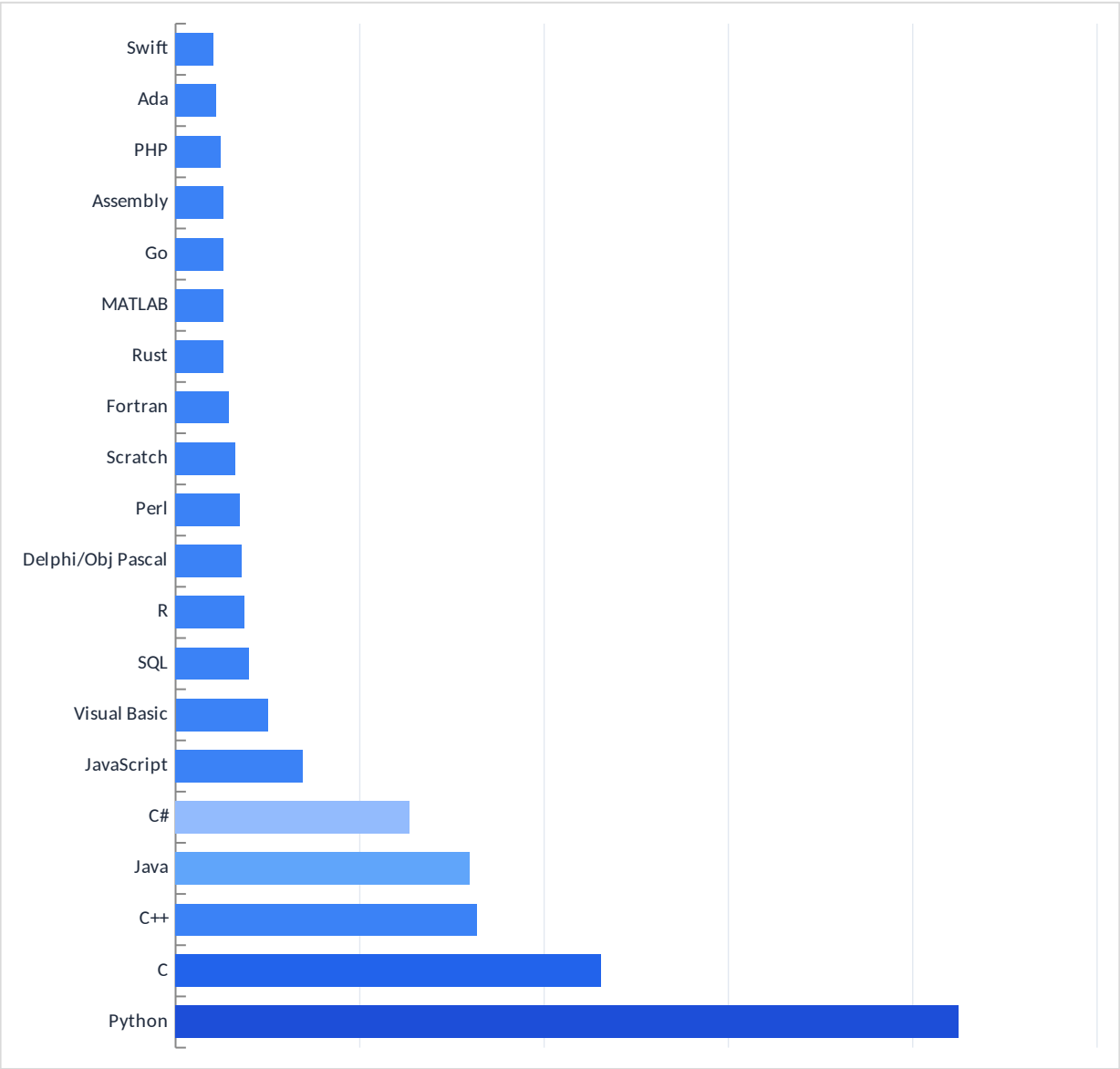
TIOBE Index March 2026

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

METHODOLOGY

Ratings are calculated from skilled-engineer counts, training courses, and third-party vendor data using search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain



Top 4 languages (Python, C, C++, Java) hold 48.97% of total index ratings				
2026	2025	Language	Rating	YoY
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Obj Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

▲ GAINERS

Perl

+13 ranks (+1.05%)

24th → 11th

Entrenched in infrastructure & text processing; community renaissance driven by Perl 5.40 ecosystem

R

+7 ranks (+0.94%)

16th → 9th

Growing demand in data science & statistical computing; complementing Python in analytics workflows

Swift

+6 ranks (+0.44%)

26th → 20th

Apple platform growth; re-enters top 20 as Kotlin drops to 22nd

C

+2 ranks (+2.02%)

4th → 2nd

Largest absolute rating gain among top 20; resilient systems language surges past C++ and Java

C#

Stable (+1.49%)

5th → 5th

2023 & 2025 Language of the Year; .NET ecosystem momentum continues

▼ LOSERS

Go

-9 ranks (-1.49%)

7th → 16th

Sharpest decline of any top-20 language; possible displacement by Rust in systems programming

C++

-1 rank (-2.90%)

2nd → 3rd

Largest absolute rating drop (-2.90pp) despite only falling one rank position

Java

-1 rank (-2.37%)

3rd → 4th

Continued long-term decline from 25%+ peak; steady erosion over past 8 years

SQL

Stable (-0.57%)

8th → 8th

Rating erosion despite holding rank; reflects shift toward NoSQL and ORM abstractions

PHP

-5 ranks (-0.25%)

13th → 18th

Gradual decline continues as modern web stacks adopt alternative backends

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python's Rise

Unranked before 1991 → #26 in 2001 → #1 by 2026. Took 25 years to reach the top.

C's Endurance

The only language in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades.

Java's Arc

Dominated 2005–2018 at 25%+, now under 8%. Classic peak-and-decline trajectory.

Lisp's Fall

#2 in 1986 → #26 in 2026. Once foundational, now niche.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language



*2017 winner not available in source data

Python

6 wins

2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024

All-time leader. Dominance built over 17+ years of consistent gains in data science, ML, and general-purpose development.

C#

2 wins

2023, 2025

Back-to-back contender. .NET ecosystem growth and cross-platform adoption fuel C#'s resurgence.

Go

1 win

2016

Won Language of the Year in 2016 but fell from 7th to 16th in 2026 — the sharpest decline of any top-20 language.

C / C++

1 win each

C: 2019 | C++: 2022

Systems programming stalwarts. C surged +2.02% in 2026; C++ declined 2.90% despite its 2022 win.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

48.97%

of total TIOBE ratings held by just 4 languages: Python (21.25%) + C (11.55%) + C++ (8.18%) + Java (7.99%)

Python: Dominant but Declining

Still #1 at 21.25% — more than double #2. But -2.59pp YoY is the largest drop among the top 5.

ACTION: Monitor Python's trajectory. Dominance is not guaranteed; plan for a multi-language future.

C Resurgence & Go's Fall

C surged from 4th to 2nd (+2.02pp). Go fell from 7th to 16th (-1.49pp), the sharpest decline in the top 20.

ACTION: For systems programming, C remains foundational. Evaluate Rust (14th, +0.09%) as Go's momentum fades.

Legacy Language Revival

Perl jumped 24th→11th (+1.05%), R rose 16th→9th (+0.94%), Fortran holds top 15.

ACTION: Don't underestimate entrenched languages. Ensure you retain or can recruit specialists in Perl, R, and Fortran for critical infrastructure.

Concentration Risk

4 languages hold ~49% of the index. 50+ other tracked languages share the remaining 51%.

ACTION: Diversify your tech stack strategically. Over-reliance on one language amplifies hiring, security, and ecosystem risks.